

FOR PM MODI AND THE BJP, GETTING ANYTHING LESS THAN A MAJORITY ON ITS OWN IN 2024 "WOULD BE A HUGE SETBACK" FOR IT WOULDN'T WANT TO BE DEPENDENT ON COALITION PARTNERS

elections where no party has won a majority on its own since 1985. In the 2019 assembly election that followed the Lok Sabha edition that year, the NDA combine won 161 of the 288 seats—well clear of the 145 seats needed for a majority. Of these, the BJP won 105 seats and the Sena, clearly the junior partner, took 56. Soon after, though, the two parties fell out over which one would take the chief ministership, with the Sena claiming there was a gentlemen's agreement before the polls to give its representative the post. The BJP was caught flat-footed when then Shiv Sena chief Uddhav Thackeray joined hands with the Congress and NCP, which had together won 98 seats, to create the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA) and emerged as the chief minister.

The BJP was acutely aware that if the MVA was allowed to continue as a united reigning force till the 2024 Lok Sabha poll, its combined vote share of 55 per cent would be almost impossible to beat. Though politics is an inexact science where two plus two need not add up to four, the party was in danger of losing many of the 41 seats the alliance had won in 2019. So, in June last year, the BJP first engineered a split in the Shiv Sena and formed a new coalition government by anointing Sena rebel leader Eknath Shinde as chief minister. Then, this July, the BJP decided to make doubly sure of its position. It split the NCP by winning over Ajit Pawar and a majority of the party's MLAs. But the BJP also came in for flak for engineering defections while claiming it was a party with a difference. An ABP poll conducted in Maharashtra saw 58 per cent respondents expressing the view that it would harm the BJP's image while 38 per cent felt it would benefit from it.

However, BJP president J.P. Nadda denies the party engineered the defections, saying, "In the BJP, right from the Jan Sangh days, our ideology has not been diluted an iota. We talked about nation and nationalism then, we do so now too. The same with Article 370, Ram Janmabhoomi or triple talaq, we stand by our beliefs and we act on them. We are the only party which has been consistent throughout, the only one that has not diluted its ideology. As for the other parties, how did we break them? They did so of their own volition. We will not compromise our ideology because they have joined us." (*see interview*: 'Opposition unity is a mirage')

THE TOUGH NUTS

As in Maharashtra, the BJP is moving ahead with its plans to neutralise the Opposition in other key states too. Bihar, with 40 Lok Sabha seats, is another swing state. The combination of Nitish's JD(U) and a resurgent RJD led by Tejashwi poses a formidable challenge. In the 2015 assembly election, when the two parties along with the Congress party formed the